

USER DATA EXPLOITATION BY BIG TECH: BALANCING PRIVACY AND
PROFIT

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the issue of user data exploitation by Big Tech companies and analyzes the ethical challenges associated with balancing user privacy and corporate profit. The study discusses how personal data is collected, processed, and utilized in modern digital platforms, as well as the factors contributing to unethical data practices. In addition, the research investigates the impacts of user data exploitation on individuals, organizations, and society, including privacy violations, cybersecurity risks, manipulation of user behavior, and the erosion of public trust.

The findings of this study indicate that profit-driven business models, weak regulatory enforcement, limited user awareness, and rapid technological advancement are among the main causes of unethical data exploitation. The study also highlights the importance of stronger cybersecurity measures, transparent data policies, ethical corporate governance, and stricter privacy regulations in addressing these issues.

In conclusion, balancing technological innovation and corporate profitability with the protection of user privacy is essential in ensuring ethical practices within the computing industry. Cooperation between governments, organizations, and users is necessary to create a safer, fairer, and more transparent digital environment.

ABSTRAK

Kajian ini mengkaji isu eksploitasi data pengguna oleh syarikat-syarikat Teknologi Besar dan menganalisis cabaran etika yang berkaitan dengan mengimbangi privasi pengguna dan keuntungan korporat. Kajian ini membincangkan bagaimana data peribadi dikumpulkan, diproses dan digunakan dalam platform digital moden, serta faktor-faktor yang menyumbang kepada amalan data yang tidak beretika. Di samping itu, kajian ini menyiasat kesan eksploitasi data pengguna terhadap individu, organisasi dan masyarakat, termasuk pelanggaran privasi, risiko keselamatan siber, manipulasi tingkah laku pengguna dan hakisan kepercayaan awam.

Penemuan kajian ini menunjukkan bahawa model perniagaan yang didorong oleh keuntungan, penguatkuasaan peraturan yang lemah, kesedaran pengguna yang terhad dan kemajuan teknologi yang pesat adalah antara punca utama eksploitasi data yang tidak beretika. Kajian ini juga menekankan kepentingan langkah keselamatan siber yang lebih kukuh, dasar data yang telus, tadbir urus korporat yang beretika dan peraturan privasi yang lebih ketat dalam menangani isu-isu ini.

Kesimpulannya, mengimbangi inovasi teknologi dan keuntungan korporat dengan perlindungan privasi pengguna adalah penting dalam memastikan amalan beretika dalam industri pengkomputeran. Kerjasama antara kerajaan, organisasi dan pengguna adalah perlu untuk mewujudkan persekitaran digital yang lebih selamat, adil dan telus.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

ANN	-	Artificial Neural Network
GA	-	Genetic Algorithm
PSO	-	Particle Swarm Optimization
MTS	-	Mahalanobis Taguchi System
MD	-	Mahalanobis Distance
TM	-	Taguchi Method
UTM	-	Universiti Teknologi Malaysia
XML	-	Extensible Markup Language
ANN	-	Artificial Neural Network
GA	-	Genetic Algorithm
PSO	-	Particle Swarm Optimization

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

Nearly all the people living in the 21st century have either connected themselves with every kind of technology. It is nearly impossible for all of us to disconnect or even avoid these kinds of things altogether. The rapid growth of digital technology has transformed the way people communicate, work, shop, learn, and interact with society. Billions of users entrust these services provided by major technology companies such as Google, Meta, TikTok, Amazon, and Apple. These companies offer free and convenient digital services including social media, search engines, cloud storage, e-commerce, and entertainment platforms. The current widespread use of these digital services has led to the large-scale collection of user data. User data refers to one's own personal information generated through online activities, including browsing history, location data, search records, purchasing behavior, device information, social interactions, and personal preferences. Big Tech companies collect and analyze this data to improve services, personalize user experiences, and most importantly, generate profit through targeted advertising and data-driven business strategies.

Over the past few years, many reports indicate several of these big companies had their data breached by unknown threat actors and most of them include customers' personal and private data. Few raised concerns regarding the trust, misuse and mishandle of user data wherever if it was even safe to begin with in the first place. Many technology companies have been criticized for collecting excessive amounts of data without fully informing users about how the data is used, stored, or shared. In some cases, user data has been exposed through security breaches, sold to third parties, or used to influence user behavior and political opinions. With these serious ethical concerns regarding privacy, security, fairness, and corporate accountability comes absolute responsibility, damage control and the massive consequences in the computing industry.

1.2 Problem Statement

Digital platforms have caused users to share large amounts of personal information often without fully understanding how their data is collected, processed, and used by technology companies willingly and also without reading the Terms of Services. Big Tech companies rely heavily on user data as a valuable asset for targeted advertising, algorithm optimization, business analytics, and artificial intelligence development. Although these practices contribute to some benefits, they create serious ethical concerns regarding user privacy and data protection. One of which is that many users are not given clear and transparent information about data collection practices. Privacy policies are often lengthy, complicated, and difficult to understand, causing users to accept terms and conditions without giving it a glance and thought. As a result, users may unknowingly allow companies to access sensitive information such as location data, online behavior, personal interests, and communication activities. Companies might also create a legal loophole that may allow them to bypass or even exploit a statement without technically breaking their word.

Some technology companies collect excessive amounts of data beyond what is necessary for their services and that could include unnecessary info. This raises concerns about surveillance, manipulation, and the misuse of personal information for commercial purposes. This could add to the fact that we are currently witnessing the rapid growth of AI technologies which has increased concerns about how user data is being used to train intelligent systems without proper user awareness or permission from the original creators.

Another major issue is the imbalance of power between technology companies and users. Big Tech corporations possess advanced technological capabilities, vast financial resources, and control over digital ecosystems, while ordinary users often lack sufficient knowledge about digital privacy and cybersecurity. This imbalance allows companies to prioritize profit and business interests over ethical responsibilities and user rights. They easily shut down comments, topics that openly discuss unethical workings of the company and also outright banned for those who are telling the truth. Not only that, there are reports that criticizes Big Tech for being

misleading, accused of censorship, a contributor of global warming and raised privacy concerns.

1.3 Research Objectives

This study seeks to answer the following questions that are relevant to this case study.

1. What ethical issues are associated with user data exploitation by Big Tech companies?
2. What are the main causes of user data exploitation in modern digital platforms?
3. How does user data exploitation affect individuals, organizations, and society?
4. What solutions can be implemented to balance privacy protection and corporate profit?

CHAPTER 2

ANALYSIS

2.1 Introduction

In today's digital environment, personal data has become one of the most valuable resources for technology companies. Large technology corporations, commonly referred to as "Big Tech," such as Facebook (now Meta), Google, Amazon, and TikTok, rely heavily on user data to improve services, personalize content, and generate profit. Every online activity, including searches, likes, comments, location tracking, and browsing behavior, contributes to a large collection of personal information that can be analyzed for commercial purposes. While these practices may improve user experience, they also raise serious concerns regarding privacy, consent, and ethical responsibility.

The collection of user data has become deeply integrated into modern digital platforms. Many users willingly share information through social media applications without fully understanding how their personal information is collected, stored, or used. Although privacy policies are available, they are often lengthy and difficult for users to understand. As a result, users may unknowingly agree to data-sharing practices that go beyond their expectations. According to Zuboff (2019), technology companies increasingly rely on what is known as "surveillance capitalism," where human experiences and behaviors are transformed into valuable data for commercial gain. In this business model, user behavior is analyzed not only to predict actions but also to influence decision-making, often without users' full awareness.

One of the most significant examples of user data exploitation by Big Tech is the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica scandal. This case attracted global attention due to the large amount of user data involved and the ethical concerns surrounding its use

for political purposes. The incident raised important questions about whether technology companies prioritize financial profit over user privacy and whether stronger protections are needed to safeguard personal information. Therefore, this chapter analyzes the Facebook–Cambridge Analytica case study to better understand how user data exploitation occurs and how the conflict between privacy and profit continues to challenge Big Tech companies.

2.2 Case Study: Facebook and Cambridge Analytica

The Cambridge Analytica scandal became public in 2018 and is widely considered one of the most controversial data privacy incidents involving a major technology platform. Cambridge Analytica, a political consulting company, gained access to Facebook user data through a personality quiz application called *This Is Your Digital Life*, created by researcher Aleksandr Kogan. The application was presented as an academic personality assessment and encouraged users to participate voluntarily. However, while only a limited number of users directly installed the application, Facebook's platform policies at that time allowed the app to access data not only from participants but also from their Facebook friends.

As a result, the personal data of millions of Facebook users were collected without direct permission. Reports later revealed that information from approximately 87 million users had potentially been accessed and used for political profiling and targeted political advertising during election campaigns, including the 2016 United States presidential election (Hu, 2020). This incident shocked many people because most affected users had no knowledge that their personal information had been shared with a third-party organization.

The case revealed weaknesses in Facebook's privacy management system. At the time, Facebook allowed third-party developers to gain extensive access to user information through its application programming interface (API). While users

technically agreed to Facebook's terms and conditions, many were unaware of the extent of data collection taking place. This raised concerns regarding informed consent, as agreeing to terms without fully understanding them cannot necessarily be considered meaningful permission.

Furthermore, the Cambridge Analytica scandal demonstrated how user data could be transformed into a valuable commercial and political resource. The company reportedly used collected information to build psychological profiles of individuals, enabling highly personalized political advertisements. Through behavioral analysis, users could be targeted based on emotions, fears, preferences, and political interests. This level of personalization highlighted the growing power of data analytics and demonstrated how personal information could influence human behavior.

2.3 Analysis of User Data Exploitation

The Facebook–Cambridge Analytica case illustrates how user data exploitation can occur when companies prioritize growth and profitability over transparency and privacy protection. Although Facebook did not directly sell user data to Cambridge Analytica, the platform’s policies enabled third-party access to personal information, creating opportunities for misuse. This situation highlights an important issue within Big Tech business models: user data has become a central economic asset.

Facebook’s business strategy heavily relies on advertising revenue, which depends on collecting detailed user information. The more data Facebook gathers, the better the company can personalize advertisements and maintain user engagement. From a business perspective, personalized advertising increases effectiveness and profitability. However, this strategy creates ethical concerns because user information becomes part of a profit-making system. In other words, privacy can sometimes be treated as secondary when compared to financial performance.

One important issue highlighted by this case is the concept of informed consent. In theory, Facebook users gave permission for data collection by accepting terms and conditions. However, many users did not fully understand how their information would be shared or how third-party developers could gain access to it. This creates a major ethical concern because consent should involve a clear understanding of what users are agreeing to. If individuals are unaware of how their information will be used, consent becomes questionable.

The scandal also demonstrated how digital platforms can influence behavior using collected information. Cambridge Analytica allegedly used psychological profiling techniques to create targeted messages designed to influence political opinions. This suggests that personal data can be used not only for commercial purposes but also to shape beliefs and behaviors. Such practices raise concerns about manipulation and the ethical limits of digital advertising.

Another important aspect of this case is accountability. After the scandal became public, Facebook faced criticism for failing to protect user privacy and for responding too slowly to concerns about data misuse. Public trust in Facebook declined, and the company faced legal investigations and financial penalties. The scandal showed that failure to protect privacy could damage corporate reputation and reduce user confidence. This demonstrates that although data exploitation may generate short-term profit, it can also create long-term risks for businesses.

2.4 Privacy vs Profit Discussion

The Facebook and Cambridge Analytica case highlights an ongoing conflict between privacy protection and profit generation within Big Tech companies. Digital platforms such as Facebook depend heavily on user engagement and advertising revenue. To maintain profitability, companies continuously collect and analyze user behavior to improve advertising accuracy and increase platform usage. From a business perspective, this approach is effective because personalized content often attracts greater user attention and improves marketing performance.

However, the problem arises when profit-driven strategies begin to challenge ethical boundaries. In the Cambridge Analytica case, Facebook's system allowed large-scale data collection that users were not fully aware of. Although the platform benefited financially from extensive data collection, concerns regarding transparency and accountability became increasingly serious. This situation suggests that maximizing profit can sometimes create environments where privacy risks are overlooked or underestimated.

At the same time, it would be unrealistic to argue that Big Tech companies should stop collecting user data completely. Data collection plays an important role in improving platform performance, providing personalized recommendations, and enhancing user experience. For example, social media platforms use data to recommend relevant content, while online shopping platforms analyze browsing history to suggest products that match user interests. Therefore, the issue is not necessarily data collection itself but rather how the data is collected, managed, and protected.

A balance between privacy and profit is therefore necessary. Companies should implement stronger transparency measures to ensure users clearly understand how their data is being used. Privacy settings should be easier to understand, and users should have greater control over the information they choose to share. Additionally, stronger regulations and ethical standards are needed to prevent companies from prioritizing profit at the expense of user rights.

The Cambridge Analytica incident serves as an important lesson for Big Tech companies. It demonstrates that while user data can create significant economic value, failure to handle that data responsibly may result in public backlash, legal consequences, and loss of trust. Therefore, sustainable business growth should involve both profitability and responsible privacy management.

2.5 Chapter Summary

This chapter analyzed user data exploitation through the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica case study. The incident revealed how personal information could be collected and used beyond users' expectations, raising concerns regarding privacy, consent, and ethical responsibility. The analysis showed that Facebook's business model, which relies heavily on user data for targeted advertising, contributed to an environment where personal information became highly valuable for commercial and political purposes.

Furthermore, the case demonstrated the tension between privacy protection and corporate profit. While data collection provides benefits such as personalized experiences and platform improvement, weak privacy controls can expose users to exploitation and misuse of information. The findings from this chapter suggest that achieving a balance between privacy and profit remains one of the greatest challenges faced by Big Tech companies. This discussion provides a foundation for the next chapter, which will further examine the causes behind user data exploitation in digital platform

CHAPTER 3

3.1 Introduction

This chapter explains the research methodology used to investigate the issue of user data exploitation by Big Tech companies. Since the study focuses on ethical concerns, privacy violations, corporate responsibility, and the impact of data-driven business models, a qualitative research approach was selected as the most suitable method. Unlike quantitative research, which focuses on numerical measurements and statistical testing, qualitative research allows deeper exploration of human behavior, ethical implications, and organizational practices. This approach is important because the issue of data exploitation involves complex social and ethical dimensions that cannot be fully understood through numerical analysis alone. Humanity really did invent a system where people trade their personal lives for free stickers and short videos, then act shocked when corporations monetize it. Extraordinary species.

The research specifically adopted a case study design to examine real-world examples of data misuse involving major technology companies. The primary case selected for this study is the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica scandal, as it represents one of the most significant examples of unethical data exploitation in the digital era. The case demonstrates how personal information collected from users can be accessed, analyzed, and used for commercial and political purposes without proper user awareness or informed consent. By focusing on this case, the study is able to analyze not only the technical aspects of data collection, but also the ethical conflicts between privacy protection and profit generation. The case also provides valuable insight into the weaknesses of platform governance, transparency, and accountability within Big Tech companies.

3.1.1 Proposed Method

A qualitative case study method was adopted to analyze the issue from ethical, social, and technological perspectives. The research process began with identifying the background of the problem and establishing the research objectives related to privacy concerns, informed consent, corporate accountability, and the effects of surveillance-based business models. Relevant literature was then collected from academic journals, conference papers, books, official reports, government regulations, and reputable online news sources. These materials were carefully selected to ensure that the information used in the study was accurate, reliable, and relevant to the topic of user data exploitation.

The collected information was organized and analyzed using thematic analysis. Several important themes were identified, including excessive data collection, third-party access to user information, manipulation through targeted advertising, behavioral profiling, lack of transparency, and ethical responsibility. Through this method, the study was able to identify patterns and relationships between corporate data practices and the risks faced by users and society. The qualitative approach also allowed the researcher to critically interpret how Big Tech companies balance commercial interests with privacy protection, rather than simply describing events at surface level. In short, the method examines not only what happened, but why it happened, how it happened, and why companies keep repeating the same behavior while issuing polished public apologies written by entire legal departments.

3.1.1.1 Research Activities

The research activities were carried out in several structured stages to ensure consistency and clarity throughout the study. First, background research was conducted to understand how modern digital platforms collect, process, and monetize user data. This stage involved reviewing existing literature related to data privacy, surveillance capitalism, digital ethics, and cybersecurity issues associated with Big Tech companies. Second, detailed analysis of the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica scandal was performed to identify the methods used to collect user information, the weaknesses in Facebook's platform policies, and the ethical concerns surrounding informed consent and political profiling.

Third, the findings obtained from the literature review and case analysis were evaluated according to the research objectives. The study examined the causes of user data exploitation, its effects on individuals and society, and the ethical conflicts between privacy and profit. Finally, the findings were synthesized into a structured thesis-style discussion to support the arguments presented in later chapters. This systematic process ensured that the research remained organized, academically consistent, and aligned with the objectives of the study. Because if methodology is weak, the entire report collapses into "I found some articles online and had opinions." Universities tend to dislike that.

3.2 Tools and Platforms

This study relied on several digital tools and academic platforms to support the research, analysis, and documentation process. Microsoft Word was used as the primary software for writing, organizing, and formatting the report according to thesis-style academic standards. Features such as heading styles, citation formatting, tables, and page layout tools were useful in ensuring consistency and improving the overall presentation of the report. In addition, Microsoft Word allowed the researchers to structure the chapters systematically and maintain proper academic formatting throughout the study. Humanity's greatest achievement apparently remains spending three hours fixing page numbering instead of solving privacy abuse. Remarkable species.

Internet browsers such as Google Chrome and Microsoft Edge were also important during the research process. These platforms enabled access to online academic databases, news articles, legal documents, and case-related reports concerning user data exploitation and digital privacy issues. Since the topic involves rapidly evolving technology and current ethical concerns, online access was necessary to gather updated information regarding Big Tech companies, data privacy regulations, and recent incidents involving misuse of user information.

Academic search platforms such as Google Scholar, ResearchGate, and online journal repositories were used to obtain scholarly articles, conference papers, and previous research related to surveillance capitalism, digital ethics, data protection, and corporate accountability. These sources provided credible and peer-reviewed information that strengthened the academic quality of the study. In addition, PDF reader software was used to review journal articles, reports, and policy documents efficiently during the literature review and analysis process. The use of these tools helped ensure that the information collected was relevant, reliable, and suitable for academic discussion.

3.3 Chapter Summary

This chapter discussed the research methodology applied in this study to investigate the ethical issues surrounding user data exploitation by Big Tech companies. A qualitative case study approach was selected because it allowed the researchers to examine privacy concerns, corporate behavior, and ethical conflicts in greater depth. The methodology focused on collecting and analyzing secondary data from reliable academic and public sources, particularly related to the Facebook and Cambridge Analytica incident. This approach was considered appropriate because the study aimed to understand ethical implications and social impact rather than produce statistical measurements.

The chapter also explained the research activities involved throughout the study, including literature review, case analysis, information comparison, and interpretation of findings. In addition, the tools and platforms used to support the research process were identified and discussed. These tools assisted the researchers in accessing academic materials, organizing information, and presenting the report in a clear and academically structured format. Overall, the methodology provided a strong foundation for the following chapters and ensured that the study remained systematic, credible, and relevant to the field of computer ethics and digital privacy.

CHAPTER 4

IMPACT

4.1 Positive impact for individual

The collection and use of user data by large technology companies provide several benefits to individuals. One of the main advantages is personalized digital experiences. Big tech companies analyze user behavior, preferences, and interests to recommend products, services, videos, music, and news that match individual needs. This personalization improves convenience and saves users time when searching for information or entertainment online.

Another positive impact is the improvement of digital services and platform functionality. User data helps companies understand customer behavior and identify problems within their systems. As a result, applications and online services can be continuously improved to provide better performance, faster response times, and more user-friendly features. Many free services, such as social media platforms, email services, and navigation applications, are made possible through data-driven advertising revenue.

In addition, data collection contributes to better security and fraud detection. Technology companies can monitor unusual activities and identify suspicious behavior patterns to protect users from cyber threats, unauthorized account access, and financial fraud. Personalized security features such as suspicious login alerts and fraud prevention systems help users maintain safer online experiences.

4.2 Negative impact for individual

Despite these benefits, data exploitation creates serious negative effects on individuals. One major issue is the loss of privacy. Many users are unaware of how much personal information is collected and shared with advertisers or third parties. Browsing history, location data, search activity, and personal preferences may be continuously monitored, making users feel that their private lives are constantly exposed.

Another negative impact is the risk of data breaches and identity theft. When large amounts of user information are stored by technology companies, cybercriminals may target these databases. If security systems fail, sensitive personal information can be leaked and misused for fraud, scams, or unauthorized transactions. Victims often experience financial losses and emotional stress as a result of stolen personal information.

Data exploitation can also influence user behavior and decision-making. Personalized algorithms control much of the content users see online, including advertisements, videos, and news feeds. This may manipulate consumer behavior and limit exposure to different opinions or viewpoints. Users may become dependent on algorithm-driven content, reducing independent thinking and increasing online addiction, especially among younger individuals.

4.3 Positive impact for organization

For organizations, user data provides valuable opportunities to improve business performance and profitability. Companies can analyze customer behavior to understand market trends, preferences, and purchasing patterns. This information allows businesses to develop targeted advertising strategies and personalized services, increasing customer satisfaction and sales revenue.

User data also helps organizations improve operational efficiency. By studying customer feedback and usage patterns, companies can identify weaknesses in their products or services and make improvements more effectively. Data analytics enables businesses to make informed decisions, reduce operational costs, and increase productivity.

Furthermore, data-driven systems support innovation and technological development. Many organizations use artificial intelligence and machine learning technologies to create smarter products, automate processes, and improve customer experiences. The ability to collect and analyze large amounts of data allows companies to remain competitive in rapidly evolving digital markets.

4.4 Negative impact for organization

Although data exploitation can increase profits, it also creates major challenges for organizations. One significant issue is reputational damage caused by unethical data practices or data breaches. When customers discover that their personal information has been misused or poorly protected, trust in the company decreases. Negative publicity may result in loss of customers, reduced brand loyalty, and declining revenue.

Organizations also face legal and regulatory risks. Governments worldwide have introduced strict privacy laws to protect consumer information. Companies that fail to comply with these regulations may face heavy fines, lawsuits, and restrictions on their business operations. Compliance with data protection standards requires significant investment in cybersecurity systems and employee training.

Another negative impact involves cybersecurity threats. Companies that collect massive amounts of user data become attractive targets for hackers and cybercriminals. Data breaches can disrupt business operations, cause financial losses, and expose confidential company information. Organizations must continuously invest in stronger security measures to reduce these risks.

Additionally, ethical conflicts may arise within organizations. Businesses often struggle to balance profit generation with respect for user privacy. Excessive focus on data monetization may encourage unethical practices, creating internal pressure on employees and damaging the organization's ethical reputation.

4.5 Positive impact for society

At the societal level, the use of user data contributes to technological advancement and economic growth. Big technology companies create digital platforms and services that improve communication, education, healthcare, transportation, and online business activities. Data-driven innovation has made many services more accessible and efficient for people around the world.

Another positive impact is the development of smarter public services. Data analytics can help governments and organizations identify social trends, improve urban planning, manage traffic systems, and respond more effectively to emergencies or public health issues. During global crises, such as pandemics, data analysis has been useful in tracking disease spread and delivering important information to the public.

Furthermore, the digital economy created by big tech companies generates employment opportunities and supports entrepreneurship. Online platforms allow small businesses and content creators to reach wider audiences and participate in global markets. This contributes to economic development and increased access to digital opportunities.

4.6 Negative impact for society

Despite these advantages, widespread data exploitation poses serious risks to society. One major concern is the spread of misinformation and manipulation. Technology companies often use algorithms that prioritize engaging content to maximize profits and user activity. This can encourage the rapid spread of fake news, misleading information, and harmful content that may influence public opinion and create social division.

Another negative impact is the erosion of privacy and civil liberties. Continuous data collection enables large corporations and even governments to monitor public behavior on a massive scale. This raises concerns about surveillance, freedom of expression, and the misuse of personal information for political or commercial purposes.

Data exploitation also contributes to economic inequality and market dominance. A small number of powerful technology companies control enormous amounts of user data and digital infrastructure. Smaller businesses often struggle to compete against these corporations, reducing market competition and concentrating wealth and influence within a few organizations.

In addition, excessive dependence on digital platforms may negatively affect social relationships and community interactions. Social media algorithms often encourage addictive behavior and emotional engagement, which can increase social isolation, anxiety, and polarization within society. Over time, people may become less aware of the importance of protecting personal privacy and digital rights.

CHAPTER 5

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

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